

The Best Time of Art

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When is the golden period for art? Is it in the past which could never appearing again, or is it the current glory that we are participate in? This question has probably been argued for centuries. In *Lives of the Painters, Sculptors and Architects*, Giorgio Vasari praises artists who are from his own time and maintains high expectation on later generations. However, Johann Joachim Winckelmann, the author of *Reflections of the Imitations of Greek Works in Painting and Sculpture*, reveals passionate adoring towards ancient Greek relics. Focusing on the two journals to answer the previous question, Vasari's and Winckelmann's perspectives on the best time of art appear distinctly in the favor of periods but logically echoing to each other.

Artists always take "complete perfection" as their constant goal from Vasari's perspective. Actively around mid-sixteen century, Vasari highly eulogizes artists in that time. The writer starts from Leonardo da Vinci, who correct errors by artists in the second age. This high Renaissance master brings up the idea of "modern" for the first time that enables art pieces approaches closer to "truth" (Vasari, 24). Paintings in this period are no longer free of order, proportion, draughtsmanship and manner. The involvement of scientific techniques enables painters to restore beauty of nature better.

Winckelmann, however, stands almost on the opposite side from Vasari's opinion. The good taste that Winckelmann lauds belongs to the beauty from past. *Laocoon*, one representational ancient Greek sculpture, vividly restore the dying moment of Laocoon and his sons (Winckelmann, 30). Audiences' eyes are able to travel around the marble piece with the twining motion of the python that connects the three human figures. The elaborate compositions, dramatic expressions and precise depictions of this piece extend the moment of death into a dynamic process.

Although the two scholars conserve different opinions on the most glory moment of art, one common idea they are sharing is that art should be higher than nature.

Michelangelo Buonarroti, the second master Vasari stresses out, has approached the “absolute perfection”. The beauty in his arts, which comes from nature but is higher than that, surpasses all art forms that ever exist. The combinations of graceful and fruitful, controlled and unrestrained, as well as utopia and realistic interlace together for one sake of achieving the truth that higher than what human eyes could able to see in everyday surroundings. *Lacoon*, thirteen centuries previously than Michelangelo, presents a surpassing truth than nature. Audiences could appreciate the beautiful bodies coming out from the marble while immerse themselves from the realistic but dramatic anguish expression of the prophets.

History of art is not about every piece of art in history, but the intentionally selected ones. The art pieces Vasari and Winckelmann have seen, or in boarder term what we have known, are the ones that have been collected. However, there are numerous arts lack the chance to present themselves. On the other hand, neither Vasari and Winckelmann, nor contemporary audiences would ever have an opportunity to approach those missing pieces. We might already lose the qualification to select the best time of art, as we are not able to glance every piece of art.

Work Cited

Preziosi, Donald, ed. *The art of art history: a critical anthology*. Oxford University Press, USA, 2009.